

The Southern Colonies: A Story of Three Worlds



A Haven for the Faithful: The Maryland Experiment

- ✦ Founded by Lord Baltimore in 1632 as a refuge for English Catholics.
- ✦ Generous land grants attracted settlers, including women like Margaret Brent, who established 1,000-acre plantations.
- ✦ The 1649 Act of Toleration provided religious freedom for all Christians—a progressive step for its time.



The assembly praised Margaret Brent, saying that 'the colony's safety at any time [was better] in her hands than in any man's.'

An Aristocratic Ambition: The Two Carolinas



North Carolina: Settled by poor tobacco farmers from Virginia, developing a society of small farms.



South Carolina: Centered on Charles Town and settled by English colonists from Barbados, who built a wealthy economy on rice and indigo cultivated by enslaved Africans.

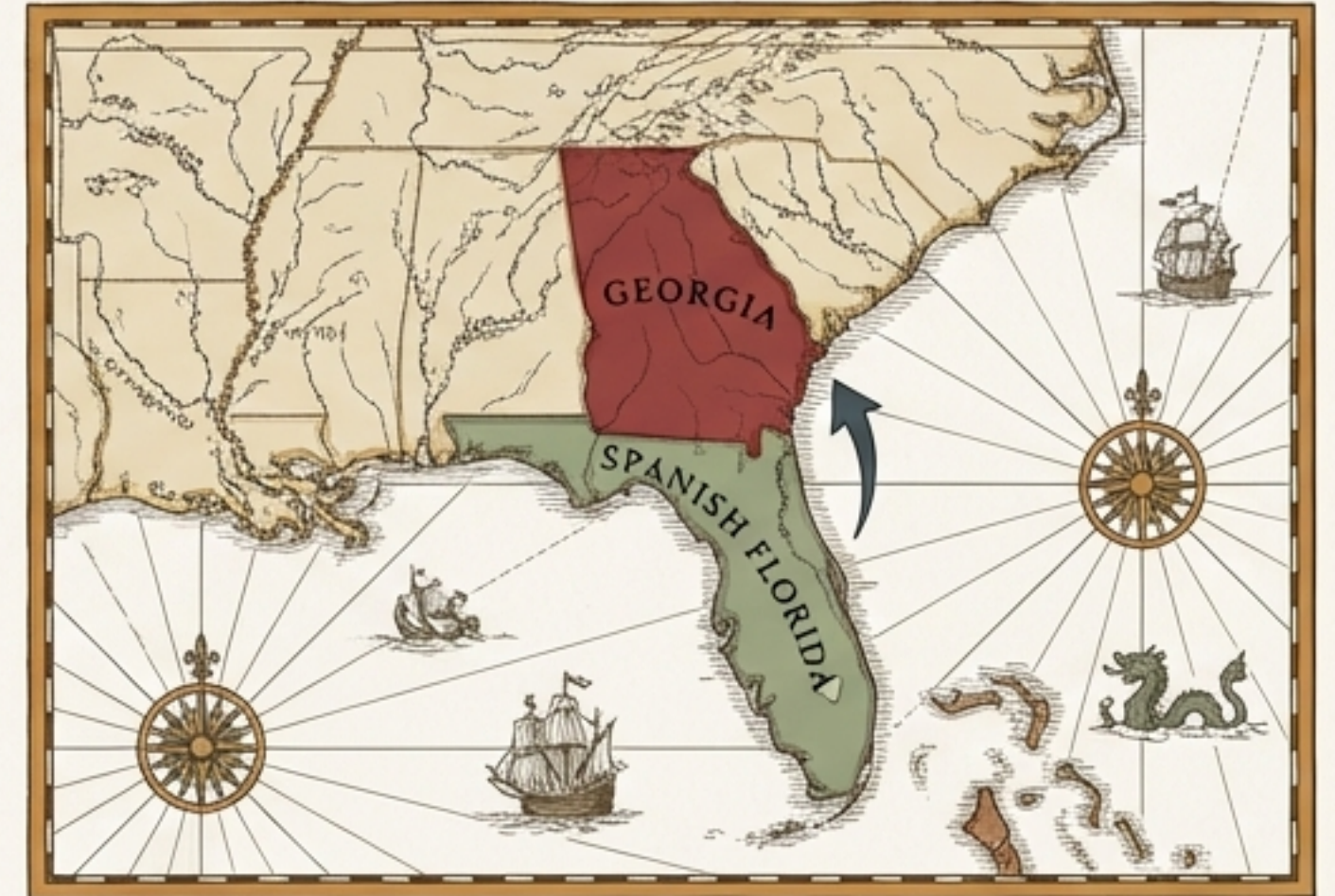


A Second Chance: James Oglethorpe's Georgia



- ⚓ Founded in 1732 as a social reform project for England's debtors and poor.
- ⚓ Served as a critical military buffer, defending the English colonies from Spanish Florida to the south.

“In America, there are enough fertile lands to feed all the poor of England.” — Oglethorpe



An Ideal Confronts Reality

THE VISION

Oglethorpe forbade slavery and limited farms to 500 acres to create a society of small, independent farmers.

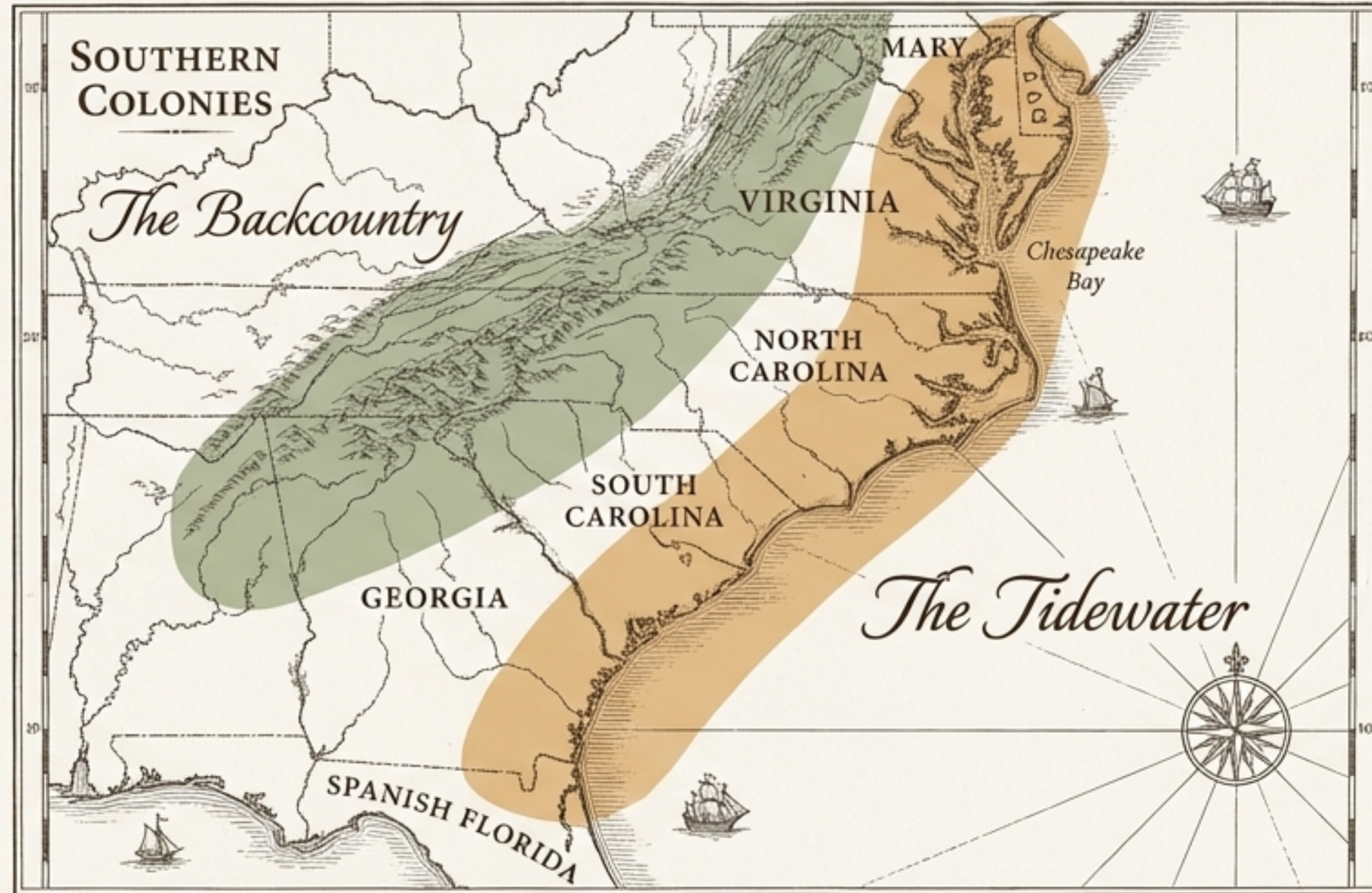


THE REALITY

To spur slow growth, the rules were reversed, allowing large plantations and slave labor, which fundamentally altered the colony's trajectory.

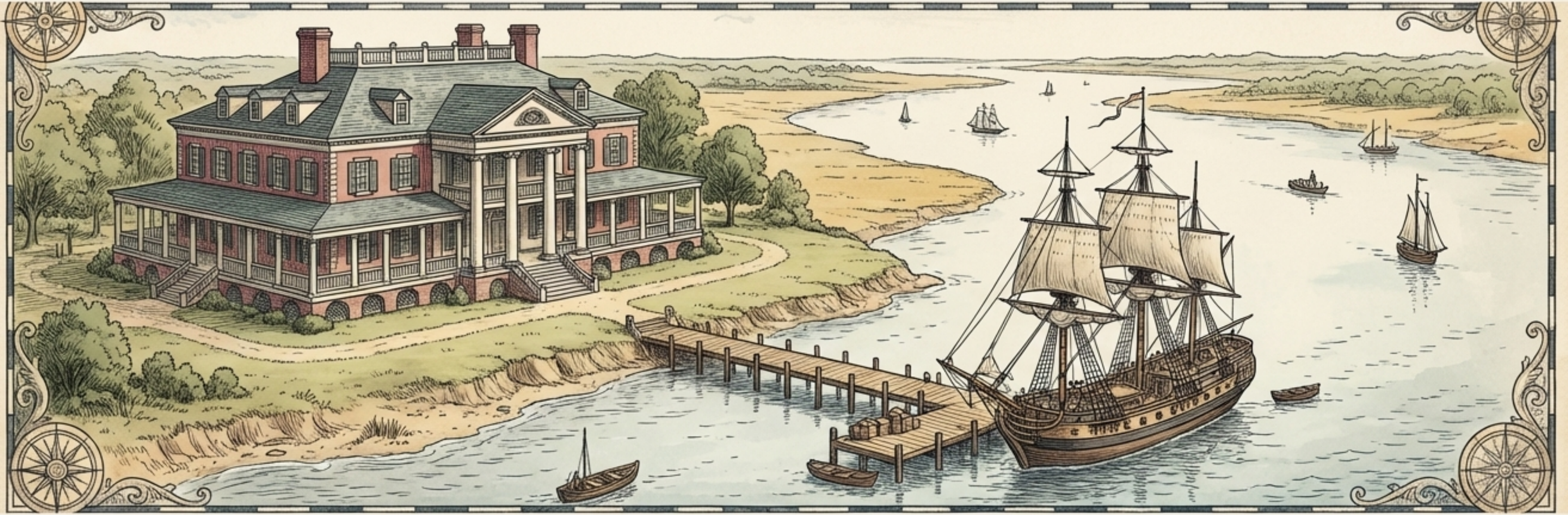


Beyond Colonial Borders, Two Souths Emerge



**Geography, more than colonial charters, shaped life in the South.
Two distinct worlds developed: the coastal Tidewater and the inland Backcountry.**

The Tidewater: A World of Grand Estates



Geography: Fertile coastal plains with slow-moving, tidal rivers.



Economy: Large plantations growing cash crops—tobacco, rice, indigo—fueled by the “headright system” that granted land for each laborer.



Society: Dominated by a planter elite. Self-contained estates with private docks meant few large cities developed.

The Backcountry: A World of Self-Reliance



Geography:

Rolling hills and thick forests at the base of the Appalachians.



People:

Settled by Scotch-Irish and German immigrants who traveled the Great Wagon Road.



Society:

More democratic and egalitarian, based on small, self-sufficient farms and a strong sense of community.



A Tale of Two Realities

TIDEWATER



ECONOMY

Plantation (Cash Crops)



LABOR

Primarily Enslaved Africans



SOCIETY

Aristocratic & Hierarchical



DEMOGRAPHICS

English Planter Elite



ACCESS

Private River Docks



BACKCOUNTRY



ECONOMY

Subsistence (Family Farms)



LABOR

Family & Community



SOCIETY

Democratic & Egalitarian



DEMOGRAPHICS

Scotch-Irish & German Immigrants



ACCESS

The Great Wagon Road

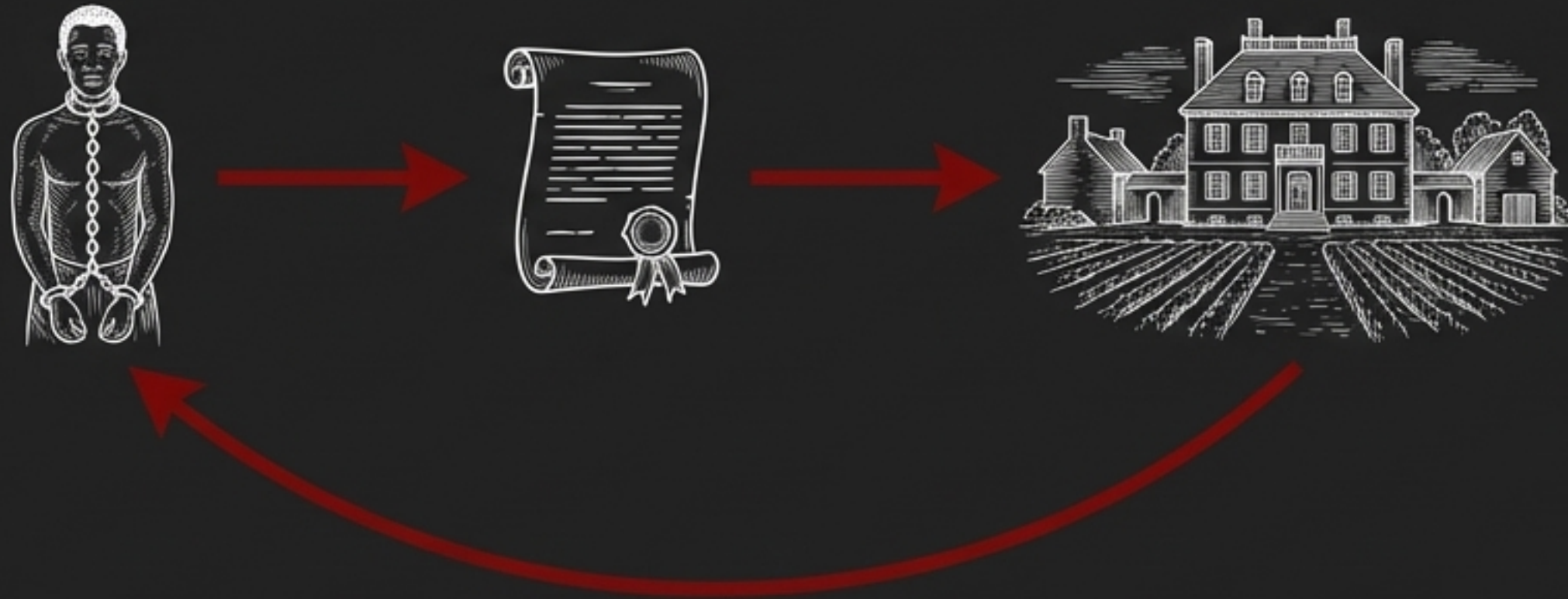


The Engine of the Tidewater

The plantation economy was built on a foundation of forced labor.

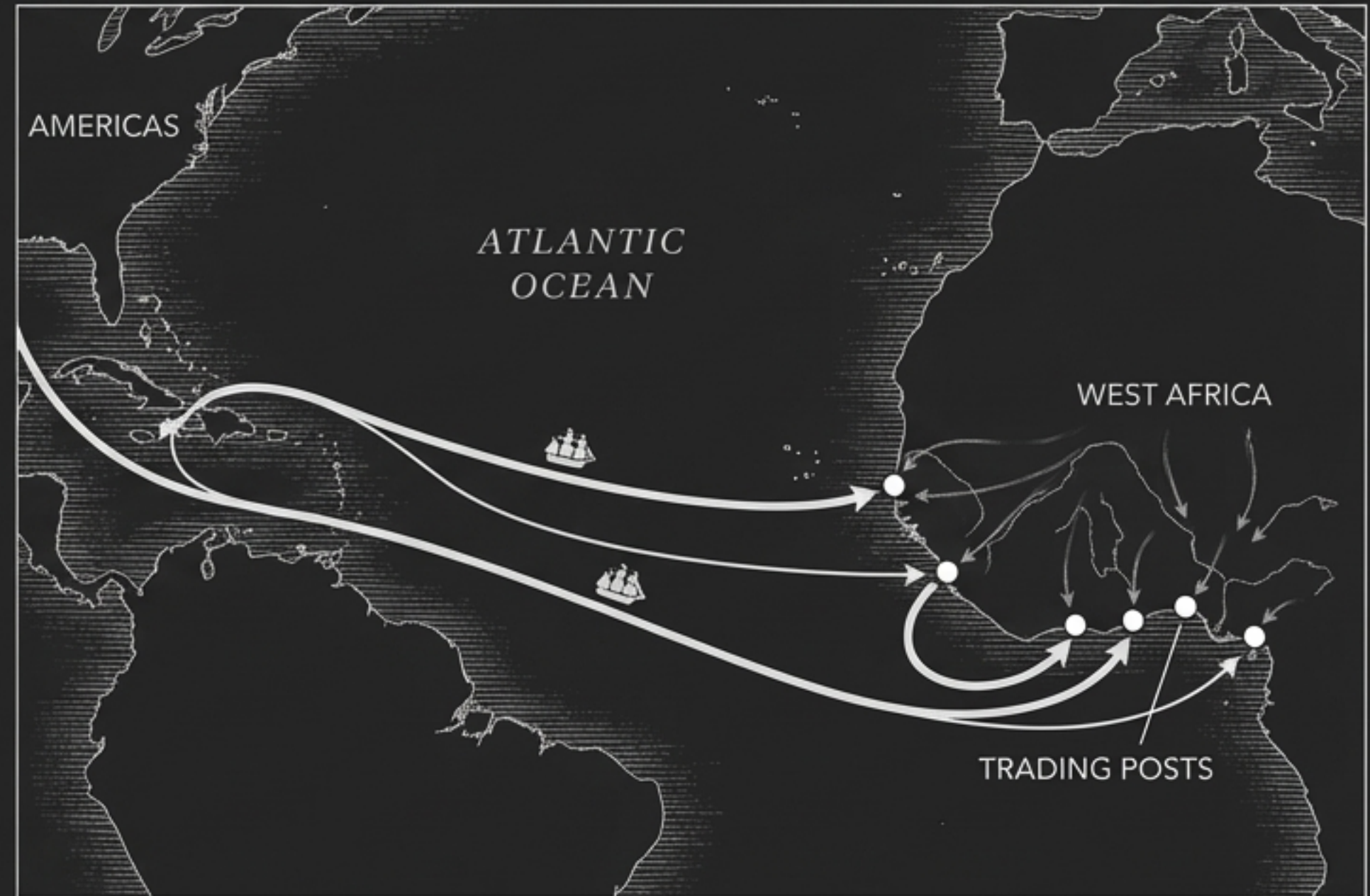
By 1700, enslaved Africans constituted the majority of the population in South Carolina.

The headright system created a vicious cycle: more slaves meant more land, which required more slaves.

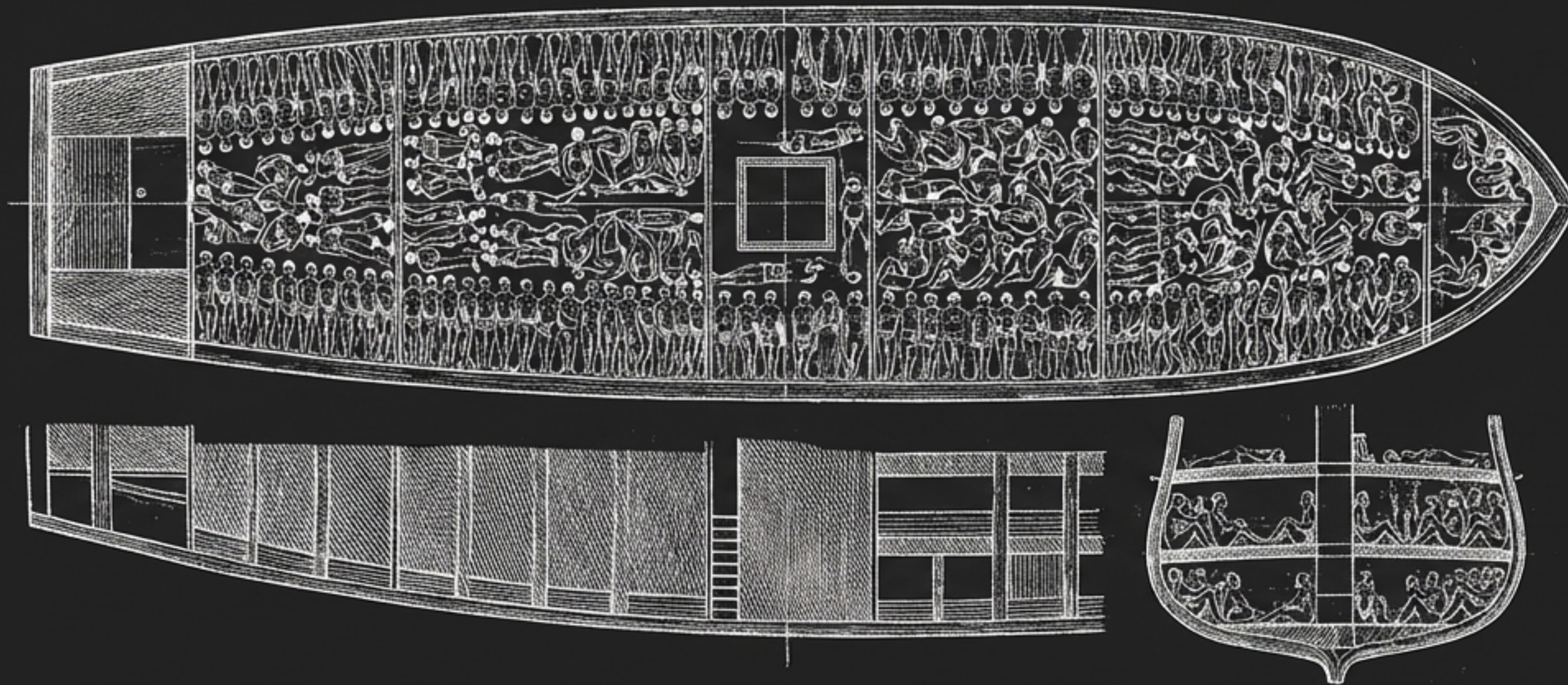


A Global Trade in Human Lives

1. European traders establish posts on the West African coast.
2. Guns and manufactured goods are exchanged for captives.
3. Africans living on the coast raid the interior, marching captives hundreds of miles to the ships.



The Middle Passage



Captives were
“**chained to each other hand and foot**, and stowed so close, that they were **not allowed above a foot and a half** for each in breadth.”

- **Resistance:** Mutinies, refusal to eat, and suicide.
- **Mortality:** Roughly **10%** of Africans died during the voyage.
- **Total Toll:** Over 300 years, an estimated **2 to 3 million** deaths during the passage alone.

From Person to Property: The Slave Codes

As slavery grew, colonies passed "**slave codes**" that legally defined enslaved Africans and their descendants as **property**.

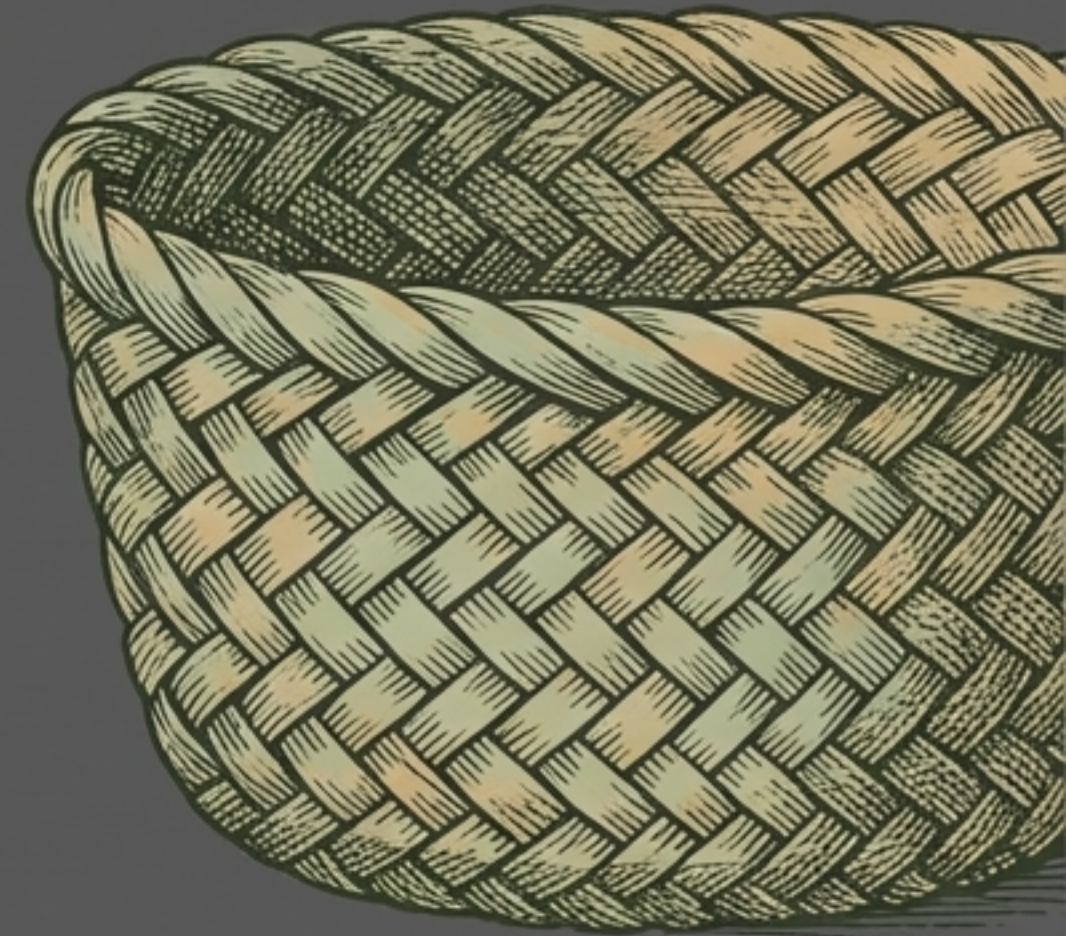
This system was **justified by racism**: the belief that one race is superior to another.

It **hardened a system** where, previously, a free African like Anthony Johnson could become a property owner in the 1600s.

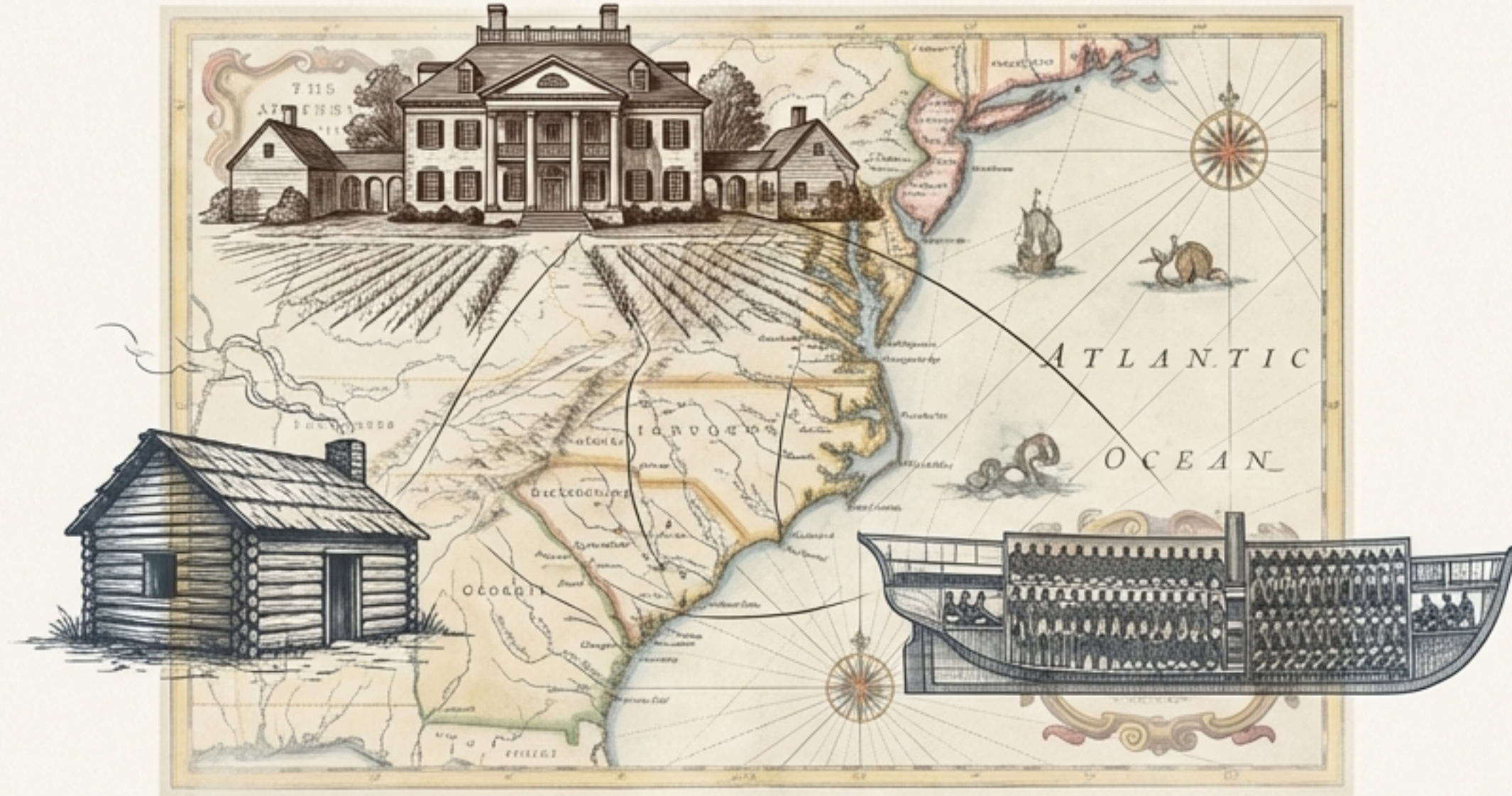


Knowledge and Resilience

- Enslaved Africans brought sophisticated agricultural skills from West Africa essential for learning how to cultivate rice.
- They introduced knowledge of native plants, using gourds for buckets and palmetto leaves for fans, brooms, and baskets.



The American Paradox



The Southern Colonies were founded on powerful ideals of freedom—for religion, for a fresh start. Their prosperity, however, was built on the **absolute denial of freedom to millions**. This contradiction would lie at the heart of the American story for centuries to come.